



# CoARA Action Plan 2024 - 2027

## Vaasa University of Applied Sciences

### Preamble

At Vaasa University of Applied Sciences, VAMK, we are committed to follow the principles of open science and research and to strengthen our expertise in open practices. We want to engage in open societal debate and promote social impact and interaction. VAMK is committed to the principles of Open Science by signing The Declaration for Open Science and Research 2020-2025. The recommendations under that Declaration outline principles for example for the responsible evaluation of a researcher.

The open culture of VAMK is built on a shared understanding and motivation to act openly and to follow open practices. The aim is to make the materials and results produced in RDI projects and the methods used available and usable to anyone who wants to use them. The open culture applies to every member of our staff, regardless of their position. We are committed to the principles of open science and research, good scientific practice, and research ethics.

VAMK is committed to good research practices in accordance with the Research Integrity Guidelines as well as The Finnish National Board on Research Integrity TENK's recommendations of authorship for research publications.

VAMK is committed to openness of learning and teaching in line with national guidelines. The promotion of open science and research can be viewed in four areas coordinated by the Delegation of the Scientific Societies. This policy focuses on openness of learning. The other three are openness of culture, openness of publishing, and openness of materials and infrastructure, which are the subject of separate guidelines.

Openness of learning links regional development, RDI work, and teaching, which are seamlessly integrated at VAMK. Openness of learning is closely linked to the overall quality of teaching. Openness in learning is our starting point, our value, and our way of working. We encourage our staff to openly share learning materials. Openness in learning is linked to accessibility and openness of learning provision. Open publishing and co-archiving are a part of VAMK's processes.

VAMK is committed to the following four principles. The first principle of the guideline states that, in addition to openness, the reliability of the teaching and the content of the open learning materials developed in connection with it, and other aspects of quality, should be assessed as the Finnish National Agency for Education suggests for e-materials. The second principle states that the development and use of open learning and open learning materials respects copyright and data protection. The third principle states that the development of open learning and open learning materials take into account their suitability and accessibility for different types of learners. And the fourth principle states that open learning and open learning materials require this work to be valued and taken into account in merit criteria and in the design of work assignments.

VAMK's open research environments include Technobothnia's laboratories, Muova's CreativeLab and CoProtolab, and Alere's learning environments. Our research environments are available to partners through our teaching, RDI, innovation and service activities.

VAMK implements an open culture which aims to make the knowledge and skills produced visible and available to all those who want to use them. Forms of openness include open publication of research data and popularisation of results, opening of research data, and open research methods. Openness promotes the impact of research results in society and enables new forms of collaboration and innovation.

VAMK has approved an open data policy in 2021. The data policy describes the organisational principles and guidelines related to the collection, use, and management of digital research data generated by the research work in VAMK. According to the FAIR principle, the aim is the retrievability, accessibility, interoperability and reusability of research data and related descriptive information, as well as referenceability and appropriate storage. The data policy guides the handling of research data generated by research conducted at VAMK and is supported by a data policy action plan.

VAMK actively participates to the policy work for promoting responsible assessment in Finland:

- Member of the National CoARA Working Group of Responsible Assessment in Finland
- Active participating in open science working groups which contribute actively to the making of national policies and recommendations
- Member of Finn-ARMA Network (*Finnish Association of Research Managers and Administrators*) which is currently sharing best practices on responsible evaluation focusing in particular on institutional level assessments
- Member of Finn-ARMA executive committee which is responsible for the on-going operations and represents the Finn-ARMA network
- Member of Finn-ARMA Publication metrics which is currently maintaining the Finnish national guide to publication metrics and sharing best practices on responsible use of publication-based metrics

VAMK signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment and joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in December 2022. By joining CoARA, VAMK commits itself to reviewing and developing the criteria, instruments, and processes of responsible research assessment (RRA).

VAMK is committed to the following CoARA commitments:

#### *Key commitments*

- Recognising the diversity of contributions to and careers in research
- Qualitative assessment as the basis for research evaluation
- Avoid inappropriate use of journal and publication-based metrics
- Avoid the use of rankings

#### *Support commitments*

- Provide resources
- Review and develop criteria, tools, and processes
- Raise awareness
- Share practices and experiences
- Communicating progress
- Evaluate practices, criteria, and tools
- Open Science

CoARA Action Plan integrates existing Responsible Research Assessment (RRA) practices and outlines further actions to implement the CoARA commitments in VAMK's everyday work and how this implementation supports the effectiveness of research outputs and the quality of research.

Implementation of the Action Plan will begin in 2025. The implementation of the RRA will be evaluated and the plan will be updated annually by the extended open science working group. The progress is reported to the management group of VAMK.

## VAMK's Action Plan for Responsible Research Assessment 2024–2027

| Promotion of Responsible Assessment                          |                                                                   |           |                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|------------------------------------------------|
| Action                                                       | Step/Milestone                                                    | When?     | Who is responsible?                            |
| Policy for responsible assessment of research and researcher | Establish the VAMK specific RRA policy                            | 2024–2025 | VAMK's working group for open science          |
|                                                              | Commitment of resources to reforming research assessment          | 2025      | VAMK's management group                        |
| Assessment reform project                                    | Extend VAMK's working group for open science for promoting of RRA | 2025      | RDI Director                                   |
|                                                              | Involve institutional community in RRA                            | 2025      | VAMK's extended working group for open science |
|                                                              | Identify key challenges to address                                | 2025      | VAMK's extended working group for open science |

| Researcher Assessment                                  |                                                                                                                   |       |                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|------------------------------------------------|
| Action                                                 | Step/Milestone                                                                                                    | When? | Who is responsible?                            |
| Implement of Career Path Model for Researchers at VAMK | Establish the VAMK specific researcher profile within the organization                                            | 2025  | VAMK's extended working group for open science |
|                                                        | Create VAMK specific career path model                                                                            | 2025  | VAMK's extended working group for open science |
|                                                        | Implement RRA criteria, tools, and processes into the recruitment process                                         | 2025  | HR together with RDI unit                      |
|                                                        | Implement RRA criteria, incentives, tools, and processes into the biannual performance evaluation and rewarding   | 2025  | HR together with RDI unit                      |
|                                                        | Implement RRA criteria, incentives, tools, and processes into the talent promotion in the Researchers Career Path | 2025  | HR together with RDI unit                      |

|                                                |                                                                                                                                                                    |           |                                                |
|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|------------------------------------------------|
|                                                | Guidelines for evaluators                                                                                                                                          | 2025–2026 | VAMK's extended working group for open science |
|                                                | Provide communication, guidance, and training on RRA criteria, processes, and their use                                                                            | 2024–2027 | RDI unit together with HR                      |
| Doctorate Program Path                         | Development of VAMK specific Doctorate Program together with University of Vaasa                                                                                   | 2025–2027 | RDI together with HR and and education units   |
|                                                | Review and develop the Researcher Career Path by following national and international recommendations and tools (e.g. Finnish Career Assessment Matrix (FINN-CAM)) | 2025–2027 | RDI unit together with HR                      |
| Career Path Model for RDI Administrative staff | Create the criteria for different levels                                                                                                                           | 2024-     | RDI unit together with HR                      |
|                                                | Implementation of Career Path                                                                                                                                      | 2025      | HR unit                                        |

| Research Assessment                                      |                                                                         |           |                     |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|---------------------|
| Action                                                   | Step/Milestone                                                          | When?     | Who is responsible? |
| Commitment to the INORMS More Than Our Rank initiation   | Write the More Than Our Rank Institutional Statement and Impact Stories | 2026      | RDI Unit            |
| Include RRA in Quality Assurance of RDI                  | Create an evaluation framework                                          | 2025–     | RDI unit            |
|                                                          | Implement evaluation framework into Project Management System           | 2025–     | RDI unit            |
|                                                          | Training how to use the evaluation framework                            | 2025–     | RDI unit            |
|                                                          | Evaluation and development of evaluation framework                      | 2025–     | RDI unit            |
|                                                          | Utilisation of Quality Data for improvement of RDI effect and impact    | 2025–     | RDI unit            |
| Share our best practices and tools (and lessons learned) |                                                                         | 2024–2027 | RDI unit with HR    |

## CoARA Working Group for Action Plan at VAMK

|                                               |                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Responsible person                            | Marja-Riitta Vest, RDI Director ( <a href="mailto:marja-riitta.vest@vamk.fi">marja-riitta.vest@vamk.fi</a> )                        |
| Contact person                                | Marja-Riitta Vest, RDI Director ( <a href="mailto:marja-riitta.vest@vamk.fi">marja-riitta.vest@vamk.fi</a> )                        |
| Other persons contributing to the Action Plan | Minna Ritari, Senior RDI Specialist<br>Anna Sjöholm, HR Director<br>Hanna-Kaisa Pernaa, Director of Unit for Social and Health Care |

## List of Links

The Declaration for Open Science and Research 2020-2025

<https://avointiede.fi/en/policies/declaration-open-science-and-research-2020-2025>

Good practice in researcher evaluation. Recommendation for the responsible evaluation of a researcher in Finland

<https://edition.fi/tsv/catalog/book/170>

Research Integrity Guidelines

<https://tenk.fi/en/research-misconduct/responsible-conduct-research-rcr>

The Finnish National Board on Research Integrity TENK's recommendations of authorship for research publications

[https://tenk.fi/sites/tenk.fi/files/TENK\\_suositus\\_tekijyys.pdf](https://tenk.fi/sites/tenk.fi/files/TENK_suositus_tekijyys.pdf)